

For This Cause Many Are Weak and Sickly

Communion Must Bring Us Free From Offense Against One Another

The Lord said, "This is what I want you to do. I want you to minister the communion table, and I want them to spend time with Me."

By the time we are done, it is my intense prayer that you will be free from anything you may be holding against one another.

As compassion teaches me about itself, certain things hurt me differently now. What hurts me more and more is people hurting each other. I used to get even, then angry. Now I see people who hurt others as people who oppose themselves.

You cannot truly damage a person who is undamageable in God. You may hurt them emotionally because they love you, but the deeper concern is the destruction you do to yourself when you hurt another person. If you have the capacity to hurt someone, or to hold offense against someone who hurt you, you oppose yourself.

The Lord wants us to enter into what He has planned for the Prayer Center free from each other. That freedom is necessary because of where He is bringing us. The devil will sniff out any handle or weakness he can use to abort what God is doing.

The New Wine of Servanthood Must Be Tasted

The Spirit of grace says: It is not a hard thing to love one another. A person who loves himself has trouble loving others, but to love one another is a matter of learning to die and turn loose of yourself.

Those who love Me will serve. I came not to be ministered unto, but to minister and give My life a ransom for many.

He who loses his life will find it. In the places where peace lives is the walk of a servant. Those who have tasted this new wine will not say the old is better.

In other words, it has to be tasted to be appreciated. You will not know what is available until you taste it.

Paul Was Addressing Why Believers Were Not Being Healed

First Corinthians 11 says:

For this cause many are weak and sickly among you, and many sleep.

For if we would judge ourselves, we should not be judged.

But when we are judged, we are chastened of the Lord, that we should not be condemned with the world.

One of the most asked questions in Pentecostal circles is why God heals some and not others. In Paul's writing to the Corinthian church, the issue was not whether it was God's will to heal everyone. The issue was why everyone was not being healed.

Today many doctrines have crept into the church. People are taught that sickness may be God making them an example of patience, or that healing is not for everyone. But the early church did not have that problem in the same way. Paul addressed sickness as something a believer could be delivered from, and then told us why some were not being healed.

In many healing meetings, God's mercy reaches people who have been taught wrong. The gifts of the Spirit compensate for bad teaching, and grace corrects error by demonstrating healing power. But Paul was addressing believers who knew they had a covenant with God that included healing.

The issue was not whether God wanted to heal. It was why so many were weak, sickly, and dying early.

The Communion Table Exposes Strife That Blocks Covenant Rights

Paul says:

He that eateth and drinketh unworthily, eateth and drinketh damnation to himself, not discerning the Lord's body.

For this cause many are weak and sickly among you, and many sleep.

The cause Paul identifies is a believer being full of unforgiveness and strife while failing to discern the Lord's body.

To fail to discern means strife has clouded the understanding of the seriousness of partaking of the Lord's body while full of division. The very strife itself causes the communion table to testify against the person.

Jesus said:

Take, eat: this is my body, which is broken for you: this do in remembrance of me.

The communion table calls us to remember His death. When He was beaten and punished, He stood under the judgment of the whole world. Because He was our substitute and Redeemer, all the hatred, unforgiveness, and strife we could ever hold against each other were laid on Him.

To hold hatred while celebrating communion is to fail to discern the Lord's body and open oneself to the sickness and disease that accompany strife under this kind of judgment.

Division Makes the Lord's Supper Impossible in Spirit

Earlier in the same chapter Paul says:

When ye come together in the church, I hear that there be divisions among you...
When ye come together therefore into one place, this is not to eat the Lord's supper.

In the communion table, the broken body of Jesus represents being set free from division and strife. To come together in one place and partake while full of division is not rightly discerning the Lord's body.

To eat the Lord's Supper while full of hatred and strife is impossible in spirit. Communion testifies of the day Jesus died and set us free from sin and division. It cannot be reduced to a powerless ceremony that complements a sinful lifestyle full of strife without invoking the judgment of God.

Jesus' Broken Body Paid for the Division in His Spiritual Body

The physical body of Jesus was a type of the spiritual body, which is the church. In the same way hatred, strife, and unforgiveness divide the spiritual body of Christ, His physical body was broken in substitution for us that He might unite us into one body.

His body was broken by the stripes laid on His back. What caused His body to be broken was the malice, strife, and unforgiveness people walk in.

Jesus was not judged because He was full of hatred and strife. He was judged because, as my substitute, He became my hatred and strife so I could go free.

Isaiah said:

The chastisement of our peace was upon him; and with his stripes we are healed.

Isaiah was seeing the punishment administered under Jewish law when men entered into controversy and were judged. Deuteronomy 25 says that if the wicked man was worthy to be beaten, the judge would cause him to lie down and be beaten according to his fault, up to forty stripes.

Jesus, as our substitute, took the maximum penalty: forty save one, or thirty-nine stripes.

The Sinless One Took Our Strife So We Could Go Free

The righteous Judge before whom Jesus stood was God. In order for Jesus to take all my hatred, strife, and unforgiveness on Himself, He had to be free from those things.

Peter wrote:

Who did no sin, neither was guile found in his mouth:
Who, when he was reviled, reviled not again; when he suffered, he threatened not...
Who his own self bare our sins in his own body on the tree...
By whose stripes ye were healed.

Jesus did not revile when reviled. He did not threaten when He suffered. He committed Himself to the One who judges righteously. He had to be free from strife to take my place in strife.

It is a serious thing to be in strife, to cause trouble, division, and hurt. Paul said that for this cause many were weak, sickly, and dying before their time.

Judgment Comes Slowly Enough That Strife Can Deceive Us

The problem with walking in unforgiveness and strife is that it is easy to deceive ourselves into thinking we are getting by with it.

This kind of judgment often manifests slowly. First it appears as weakness. Then a person's health breaks down through one disease after another: arthritis, diabetes, heart problems, blood problems, and other afflictions. Eventually the combination brings premature death, or at least a life of weakness and pain.

But Paul says:

If we would judge ourselves, we should not be judged.

The communion table brings believers face to face with the consequences of unrepented strife and unforgiveness. When revelation reaches the heart, we become accountable. The broken body of Jesus is enough revelation to judge ourselves by.

We Can Pray for Deliverance From Strife as We Pray for Healing

The same way a person prays for healing or prosperity, he can pray to be healed of unforgiveness and strife.

We pray for healing because we know Jesus bore our sicknesses and carried our pains:

"Father God, I thank You that Jesus bore my sicknesses and carried my pains. Because He suffered these things in my place, I thank You for healing me and setting me free."

We pray for deliverance from poverty because 2 Corinthians 8:9 says:

Though he was rich, yet for your sakes he became poor, that ye through his poverty might be rich.

So we can also pray:

"Thank You, Jesus, for taking my place in strife and unforgiveness. You were judged for the hateful things people do to each other. The chastisement of my peace was upon You, and with Your stripes I am healed. Father, thank You for healing me and breaking the power of strife in my life."

Emotions Must Be Turned, Not Merely Dismissed

It was not a pretty sight when Jesus received the thirty-nine stripes on His back. The scourge was not designed to raise welts but to tear flesh. God help me never to be so deceived that I let Jesus take that beating for me in vain because I esteem a position held in strife more than the people I am hurting.

Sometimes hurt runs so deep that forgiveness seems almost impossible. You may be completely innocent and have someone do something so offensive that you cannot let it go.

Emotions are powerful. They are where unforgiveness and hatred get their strength. In reality, emotions can be stronger than the will because emotions deal with our "want to."

Most of us have tried to forgive by making a willful decision, only to find ourselves back in the same place almost immediately. What we failed to understand is that emotions cannot merely be dismissed. They must be turned.

When we make the willful decision to forgive, the emotions must be subjected to something that turns them from opposing the will to supporting it.

That something is worship, especially private worship. It begins as a willful decision to call good things down on your enemy and ends in the transformation of your soul, where your emotions become free from holding anything against anyone.

Communion Is a Place to Remember, Judge, and Go Free

We may never sit down together in this lifetime for the Lord's Supper because our lives move in different directions, but heaven is another story.

I cannot think of a better way to begin this next year than remembering what Jesus did and checking our lives to make sure we are not straying from the path He paid so much to put us on.

When I take communion today, I will remember you as my friend and pray for you to prosper. I pray you do the same for me.

As we prepare the communion table, take time to commune with Him. Invite Him to search your heart. Get free today.

If you make no other decision, use your will to choose the prayer life. Prayer will eventually bring your emotions into line and support your decision to forgive.

Prayer Before the Table Releases Offense and Receives Healing

Father, as in the instructions for moving mountains and giving, You also instructed us to forgive every trespass we have against one another. Your operation in our life is put on hold when we refuse forgiveness, and condemnation with the world begins to come because covenant rights are rendered ineffective.

None of us wants to die and go home early. We have too much to do.

Right now, in the mighty name of Jesus, we bare our hearts. We make a willful decision to worship You and glorify You. We choose to release unforgiveness, hatred, strife, and division. We choose, in the face of this communion table, to let it all go in the name of Jesus.

Father, You defeated strife as thoroughly as You defeated sickness and poverty. You took our lack of peace and laid it on Jesus.

When we break the bread and take it, we want You to know that we know we are healed. We hold nothing against anyone. We examine ourselves and rightly discern the broken body. We will not eat and drink judgment.

Amen.

The Bread and Cup Proclaim the Death That Sets Us Free

Paul wrote:

For I have received of the Lord that which also I delivered unto you,
That the Lord Jesus the same night in which he was betrayed took bread:
And when he had given thanks, he brake it, and said, Take, eat: this is my body, which is
broken for you: this do in remembrance of me.

Jesus, we remember.

Take and eat.

After the same manner He took the cup:

This cup is the new testament in my blood: this do ye, as oft as ye drink it, in remembrance of me.

For as often as ye eat this bread, and drink this cup, ye do shew the Lord's death till he come.

Jesus, we remember.

Take and drink.

Worship Thanks Him for Freedom From Strife

Father, I glorify You and praise Your holy name. I magnify You, extol You, and thank You that I am free.

We are facing the greatest year ever. Thank You for privileging us with the communion table. Thank You for illuminating us and setting our path so our feet can walk righteously before You. We will absorb Your blessings and become a blessing to someone else.

We surrender ourselves to You. Thank You for freeing us from strife and healing us from hurt. By Your stripes I was healed, because my lack of peace was laid upon Jesus. I am the recipient and the beneficiary. I have been healed.

In Jesus' name, I willfully decide to love everybody. Holy Spirit, You will do the transformation.

Glory be to God forever. Thank You for healing me, and thank You for healing them.